

Spirit of the Game – UKU Policies

Introduction

Spirit of the Game (SOTG) is the first rule of Ultimate. Please take some time to read rule 1 in full here: [rules of Ultimate](#).

SOTG is summarised as follows:

“All players are responsible for administering and adhering to the rules. Ultimate relies upon a Spirit of the Game that places the responsibility for fair play on every player. It is trusted that no player will intentionally break the rules; thus there are no harsh penalties for breaches, but rather a method for resuming play in a manner which simulates what would most likely have occurred had there been no breach. Highly competitive play is encouraged, but should never sacrifice the mutual respect between players, adherence to the agreed-upon rules of the game, or the basic joy of play.”
WFDF

UK Ultimate (UKU) seeks to protect and promote SOTG as one of the core elements of the sport. We wish to see:

- UKU tournaments / events played in a positive spirited atmosphere with all teams and players upholding SOTG.
- Teams representing UK Ultimate showcasing the best of SOTG. This covers GB national teams and also club teams that are taking up UKU-allocated places at international club events such as those run by WFDF, EUF and BULA.

We recognise that from time to time there will be challenges to our goals. The policies below set out our processes and our responses to various challenges. It is important to read the definitions in the appendix alongside the main policies. We are mindful of the fact that it is each player's responsibility to uphold SOTG and the first aim of these policies is therefore to encourage all teams and players to uphold their existing responsibilities. Where it appears that these responsibilities may not be being followed, the policies act to encourage adherence by use of notification, education and, if necessary, sanctions.

1. SOTG scoring at UKU events

BEFORE EVENT:

- Every UKU event will have a unique SOTG form created by the UKU events team.

AT EVENT:

- The SOTG form will be live throughout the event. Teams are responsible for submitting scores for every game they play. Some scores require a comment (see appendix). Scores should be submitted by midnight on the last day of the event, scores submitted after this time may not be included in the spirit results or data.

AFTER EVENTS:

- UKU processes the SOTG data and publishes results and breakdowns [here](#). Read more about how the UKU SOTG Committee processes SOTG data [here](#).
- The UKU SOTG Committee reviews scores and reserves the right to contact any team based on the scores and / or comments they have submitted, scores and / or comments left by other teams, or overall results. A team will always be contacted if they receive a triggering score.

2. How should UKU respond to triggering spirit scores or comments (*see appendix for definition of triggering scores*)

The principle here is to make sure that the team / club:

- is made aware of the score and / or comment
- is clear on how the SOTG scoring system works
- recognises why their score and / or comment has triggered a response from UKU
- suggests appropriate action themselves

Where the score or comment has triggered a UKU response, UKU should offer support where possible. We expect that most teams / clubs will use this trigger and take appropriate action internally – the steps and sanctions referred to later in this document are only required if we do not consider appropriate steps to have been taken.

Guide to an initial UKU response:

Email from UKU to the team representative outlining:

- The event name and date
- The results and breakdown, including any comments.
- A request that the team responds to acknowledge that the information has been given to them and that they will investigate and take action internally.
- A request that they will outline the steps they will be taking.
- An offer of support if they wish to discuss methods to improve their spirit. This could take the form of a representative of UKU (a SOTG committee member, Board member or other designated person) talking through with them where they think their problems are, and suggested methods to take action. If requested by the team, and if a person is available, there may be the opportunity to watch one of the team's games and provide further feedback.
- Optional request, if they have it, to share suitable video footage to provide more detailed context and support understanding of SOTG. This may also provide the SOTG Committee with content to create resources for the community in the future.

Online call with the club and UKU representatives

If the email communication with a team raises concerns for any reason or follow up is required, UKU may request a call with the club to discuss the matter before any further action is decided upon.

Put the team on a monitoring list.

The SOTG Committee will maintain a record of contact with clubs. In some cases the SOTG Committee will maintain a monitoring list and may decide to check a team or club's scores at future events. A team will remain on the monitoring list until the team / club plays 3 consecutive major events with either a score above 10 or in the top three quarters of scores given in a tournament.

3. How to respond to teams on the monitoring list that receive a further triggering SOTG score

The aim of these policies is to encourage teams to take their own responsibilities towards SOTG seriously. If a team that is being monitored then achieves a further triggering SOTG score or comment, it is an indication that they may not be taking effective steps to improve SOTG.

These teams should be informed of their scores / comments and the SOTG committee will email the team spirit captain / other appropriate contact noting that despite prior notification, SOTG does not appear to have improved and that now a formal response is required. The team must respond to this within 30 days stating acknowledgement of scores and steps taken (both the actions that were previously taken, if any, and a new plan). The SOTG committee will consider whether the response is adequate:

- If adequate, the team will remain on the monitoring list for a further 12 months during which time further TRIGGERING SPIRIT SCORES will require further emails and responses and may trigger SANCTIONS (see below).
- If not adequate then the SOTG committee will refer the matter to a UKU Conduct Committee who may consider possible sanctions.

Possible Sanctions

(Note: sanctions will not be applied based solely on the scores that a team is given by other teams, but because the UKU feels that a team has not responded correctly to the process and the warnings given. The scores a team receives are only part of the information that will be used to determine whether sanctions are appropriate. A team will not have the power to force sanctions upon another team by deliberately giving a low score, and any such attempt would be treated severely.)

The SOTG committee will review all SOTG scores received to date on the team in question and the responses and action plans proposed so far. If desired, the SOTG committee can ask individual teams for feedback on any games they have had with the team in question. The SOTG committee may then propose sanctions from the list below (any combination of sanctions may be selected depending on the specifics of the case) to a UKU Conduct Committee who will make the final decision on whether or which sanctions to impose:

- Compulsory attendance of captain/all of team to a SOTG training session
- Disqualification of team from previous events where a TRIGGERING SPIRIT SCORE has been received – including loss of titles and any ranking points
- Monitoring of future games at major events by a UKU-appointed person to report on their SOTG. UKU's costs for this to be paid by the team (ie. the travel and time costs of the appointee, likely to be in the range of £100-£200 per event)
- Elimination of team from all future major events that season
- Deselection of any or all players on that team from current or future GB programmes – this step would only be taken after considering the individual's personal contribution towards the poor spirit scores
- Elimination of that team from all future UKU Ultimate events
- Non-selection of that team for future representative events (eg EUCC, EMUCC, WUCC, WMUCC ... and others)
- Loss of UKU membership for captain / all players on the team for up to 6 months – no refunds to be given

Note: sanctions will be decided by the appropriate committee based upon the severity of the breaches.

4. What to do if a team does not use the SOTG scoring system properly?

The SOTG scoring system relies on teams submitting scores for all opponents that have been fairly considered.

If it appears that a team is not using the scoring system properly, then advice should be given. This may be picked up during an event by the TD or by UKU during or after the event. Not using the system properly MAY be indicated by giving out extremely high or low scores (scores of 0, 1, 2, 3 or 18, 19, 20) although these may be perfectly correct.

If there is suspicion that scores at a major event have been deliberately 'rigged' in order to affect overall averages rather than to report upon an individual game then this should be treated very seriously by UKU and all potential sanctions could be considered.

UKU should periodically ensure that the SOTG scoring system is explained.

5. What to do if a team does not submit SOTG scores

The SOTG scoring system relies on all teams assessing and scoring the SOTG displayed by their opponents. If scores are not submitted to the tournament director then the system cannot work properly.

All teams should therefore make time to submit properly considered scores. It is up to all players on a team to help this process. If your Spirit Captain does not involve you in the scoring process then please remind them of their responsibilities to ensure that properly considered scores are submitted (perhaps they have just forgotten to score the game).

If a team does not submit scores for 2 consecutive major tournaments then UKU will contact them to note the omission. If that team then fails to submit scores at the next event then UKU may consider sanctions against them which may include:

- Loss of all or some ranking points from any events where SOTG scores have not been submitted
- A fine of up to £100 for each event for which scores have not been submitted in the last 12 months

- Other appropriate sanction

Note: UKU accepts that at times, adverse weather conditions and time pressures make submission of scores more difficult. UKU will take this into account when considering actions to take against a team that has not submitted scores.

6. Spirit Captains

It is expected now that all teams have at least one Spirit Captain and for these people to make themselves known to the opposition before the start of games. The person(s) selected as Spirit Captain should have a suitable level of experience, knowledge and skill.

Representative teams (see appendix for definition) will be required to have a Spirit Captain and attend any Spirit Captain meetings requested by the tournament organiser.

UKU will run an annual Spirit Captain meeting for university clubs which should be attended by at least one representative of all clubs competing that season. UKU will review the content of this meeting and how it is delivered. If a club does not attend Spirit Captain meetings or other SOTG meetings, UKU reserves the right to prevent event entry until the team has attended or has met with a UKU representative. UKU will review the need for Spirit Captain meetings for clubs.

Spirit Captain meetings are an opportunity to support clubs and individuals with SOTG in general, spirit scoring and the role of the Spirit Captain. They are also an opportunity to raise any issues, developments or changes related to SOTG. It is expected that clubs send a representative to the meetings.

There is no sanction for not having a Spirit Captain, however, if a team receives a triggering score and / or comment they will be asked to appoint a Spirit Captain and for this person to be available as a point of contact moving forward. With support from UKU as required, the team will be expected to have a Spirit Captain at future events.

7. What training to give to GB / Representative teams

As representatives of UKU, GB teams should have a discussion including the whole team on SOTG before competing in any tournament. This can be led by the Captain, Spirit Captain, Coach / Manager or by a UKU representative. During this discussion it should be emphasized that UKU wants all national teams to play with good spirit and respect for their opponents and to lead the way internationally with regard to SOTG.

If a tournament is more than 3 days long then there should be another team discussion of SOTG so far in the tournament before the end of the 3rd day of play. Some tournaments of this nature publish SOTG scores and comments throughout the event and these should be reviewed / used throughout the tournament to address any issues.

7.1. Feedback from Representative teams

A representative team is either a national (Great Britain) team or a club representing UKU at an international event, inclusive of EUF events, WFDF events and some BULA events.

UKU will ask all team captains for feedback on their team's approach to SOTG and the score that they have received. For teams finishing in the bottom third of their division, this feedback will be compulsory. The feedback should:

- State whether (and how many) 'formal' SOTG discussions were had within the team
- State whether in their view the SOTG scores that they received were appropriate
- Give an assessment of their view of the reasons for the score and for a list of significant events that occurred
- State whether they consider that any particular players share extra responsibility for the score
- State whether or not changes were made during the tournament because of SOTG issues
- Give suggestions for how improvements can be made in the future

After the event UKU should gather the feedback above – ensuring a response is received from all teams in the bottom third. Feedback should be reviewed and consideration as to whether to make improvements for the future should be considered. For teams that finish in the bottom 15% UKU should consider what action to take (if any). This may include:

- Taking no action (after reviewing feedback)
- Not entering GB teams in that division until SOTG issues are resolved
- Providing better SOTG training to GB captains and players in future
- Barring certain players / captains from one or more future GB teams
- Barring the players / team involved from taking up UKU allocated places at 1 or more future international events
- Any other training, sanctions or actions considered appropriate

8. UKU SOTG Awards and SOTG recognition

In 2022 UKU took a decision to change the way we process, publish and celebrate SOTG.

Youth (U20, U17 and U14)

There is no change to UKU Youth events which have a SOTG trophy that is awarded to the winning team in each division at the end of the event.

University and Club

SOTG results and breakdowns from UKU events are published on a [microsite](#), managed by the UKU SOTG Committee. This site collates all results over a season and aims to be a way to maintain a SOTG results archive over many years. We have started a move away from thinking about SOTG winners on an event-by-event basis and want to help teams and clubs see SOTG as something long-term that they are working towards. Spirit results and breakdowns are published for all events. There are no SOTG trophies to mark the event 'winner'.

There will be two annual awards:

- **SOTG Club of the Year Award** - to be announced in celebration of International Spirit of the Game day (the first Saturday in December).
- **SOTG University Club of the Year Award** - to be announced at University Mixed Outdoor Nationals (UXON) in the summer

To calculate scores for the annual award data across the three divisions (O,W,X), age divisions and teams within a club are combined. Results from Indoors, Outdoors and Beach are included. Some events run by WFDF, EUF and BULA will also be included where the SOTG data can be accessed in a suitable format.

Representative teams

UKU aims to recognise and celebrate teams that win SOTG internationally.

APPENDIX – DEFINITIONS

Scores requiring a comment

Individual scores of 4 or 0 or total scores of above 14 or below 6 are exceptional and MUST be accompanied by comments explaining the score for each category. Scores may be deleted if the comment does not explicitly refer to the category for which the low or high score was given, and/or does not provide sufficient information from which the opposing team can use to help improve their spirit, or commend the team on the details of their performance.

What is a TRIGGERING spirit score?

We continue to believe that the publication of SOTG scores and comments tends to apply peer pressure on teams and players to respond if they feel their marks indicate that they are displaying below average spirit. However we feel that as a governing body there comes a point where we must ensure that teams are aware of their scores and are encouraged to take action to improve if required.

Under the WFDF SOTG scoring system, a score is out of 20. A score of 10 is considered 'as expected'. Clearly a low spirit score is not proof of poor spirit but it does provide the most objective measure currently for indicating issues with spirit. UKU defines a TRIGGERING spirit score requiring a response as:

- 2 major UK events in a season with an average score below 9
- 1 major UK event with an average score of below 8
- 2 or more individual game scores in a single major UK event of 6 or below

(these scores to be reviewed by the SOTG committee annually to assess whether they are still appropriate indicators for triggering further action)

What is a triggering comment?

Some comments trigger a response from the SOTG Committee as a proactive step. These include the following:

- A reference to 'dangerous play'
- A comment deemed to be offensive or inappropriate
- A comment that raises concern for another reason

Comments that may be deleted or redacted:

- Any reference to a player's name or shirt number will be anonymised or redacted

- Emojis will be deleted where the meaning is not immediately clear
- Use of slang or in-jokes that is not immediately obvious is likely to be deleted
- A comment deemed to be overly personal, offensive or inappropriate
- A comment that is deemed non-sensical or unrelated

Other triggers

- Misuse of the scoring system:
 - Inconsistent inter-club scoring
 - Self-scores
 - High or low scores unjustified by comments
- Failure to submit scores

Major UK event

Defined as each of:

- UKU Tour events
- [Events run in partnership with UKU](#) where Spirit scores are collected by UKU.
- Nationals qualifiers or regionals
- National Championships
 - Grass, Beach, Indoors
 - Youth/Junior, University, Club
- Any other event from time to time considered by UKU as a major event (allowing flexibility to include one-off events)

Representative Teams

This is either:

- A national squad (GB) – playing at the international tournament for which they have been selected or at any warm-up tournament.
- A club team taking up UKU-allocated places in an international event run by WFDF, EUF or BULA.

Such teams should aim to provide a great example of SOTG. As such we ask such teams to emphasise the importance of playing with SOTG and we hope that they strive to represent UKU as well in the SOTG rankings as they are able to in tournament finishing positions.

Many events now require players to have advanced WFDF Rules Accreditation. The UKU SOTG committee believes that all players should have or be working towards this accreditation.